

2c. Content of Philosophy of religion (H573/01)

This component explores philosophical issues and questions raised by religion and belief.

Ancient philosophical influences provides important foundational knowledge for the study of philosophy of religion. This and *Soul, mind and body* enable the exploration of philosophical language and thought through significant concepts and the works of key thinkers.

Learners will critically analyse three contrasting arguments regarding the existence of God. Such arguments are a fundamental element of philosophy of religion, as well as key to the personal beliefs of many individuals.

Learners will also be introduced to different types of religious experience, and will be encouraged to discuss and debate the significance and meaning of

such experiences, as well as how they can shape religious belief.

The problem of evil and suffering will also be explored. Debated for millennia, this issue is still relevant and problematic for many today.

Through studying the nature of God, learners will explore how ideas within philosophy of religion have developed over time, and make comparisons between the ideas presented in works of key scholars.

Finally, the two sections that focus on religious language give learners the opportunity to examine issues such as whether religious teachings should be understood symbolically or analogically, or whether religious language should be regarded cognitively or non-cognitively.

Technical Terms

While the majority of non-English terms (which are not names of texts, philosophical schools or particular religious approaches) within the specification and assessment materials will be accompanied by a translation, there are some which are considered to be key technical terms that learners are expected to recognise and understand without a provided translation.

For this component the following are considered technical terms and will not necessarily be accompanied by a translation:

- *a posteriori*
- *a priori*
- *via negativa*
- *via positiva*.

1. Philosophical Language and Thought

Learners will study significant concepts and issues in the philosophy of religion through the works of key thinkers

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Ancient philosophical influences*	- the philosophical views of Plato, in relation to: - understanding of reality - the Forms - the analogy of the cave - the philosophical views of Aristotle, in relation to: - understanding of reality - the four causes - the Prime Mover	- Plato's reliance on reason as opposed to the senses - the nature of the Forms; hierarchy of the Forms - details of the analogy, its purpose and relation to the theory of the Forms - Aristotle's use of teleology - material, formal, efficient and final causes - the nature of Aristotle's Prime Mover and connections between this and the final cause
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to the ideas of Plato and Aristotle, including: - comparison and evaluation of Plato's Form of the Good and Aristotle's Prime Mover - comparison and evaluation of Plato's reliance on reason (rationalism) and Aristotle's use of the senses (empiricism) in their attempts to make sense of reality	
	Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas of Plato and Aristotle listed above can be found in:</i> - Plato, <i>Republic</i> Book 474c–480; 506b–509c; 509d–511e; 514a–517c - Aristotle, <i>Physics</i> II.3 and <i>Metaphysics</i> V.2 Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Annas, J. (1998) <i>An Introduction to Plato's Republic</i>, Oxford University Press, Chapters 9 and 10 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy (2004, rev.2013), <i>Plato</i>, http://plato.stanford.edu/entries/plato/	

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Soul, mind and body*	- the philosophical language of soul, mind and body in the thinking of Plato and Aristotle - metaphysics of consciousness, including: - substance dualism - materialism	- Plato's view of the soul as the essential and immaterial part of a human, temporarily united with the body - Aristotle's view of the soul as the form of the body; the way the body behaves and lives; something which cannot be separated from the body - the idea that mind and body are distinct substances - Descartes' proposal of material and spiritual substances as a solution to the mind/soul and body problem - the idea that mind and consciousness can be fully explained by physical or material interactions - the rejection of a soul as a spiritual substance
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to ideas about soul, mind and body, including: - materialist critiques of dualism, and dualist responses to materialism - whether the concept of 'soul' is best understood metaphorically or as a reality - the idea that any discussion about the mind-body distinction is a category error		
Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas Descartes listed above can be found in:</i> - Descartes, <i>Principles of Philosophy</i>, I.60–65 Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Blackmore, S. (2010) <i>Consciousness; an introduction</i>, Routledge, Chapters 1, 2 and 17 - Ryle, G. (1949 – many editions available) <i>The Concept of Mind</i>, Chapter 1 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy (2003 rev. 2009) <i>Ancient Theories of the Soul</i> http://plato.stanford.edu/entries/ancient-soul/		

2. The Existence of God

Learners will study contrasting arguments about the existence or non-existence of God

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Arguments based on observation*	- the teleological argument - the cosmological argument - challenges to arguments from observation	- details of this argument including reference to: - Aquinas' Fifth Way - Paley - details of this argument including reference to: - Aquinas' first three ways - details of Hume's criticisms of these arguments for the existence of God from natural religion - the challenge of evolution
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to arguments for the existence of God based on observation, including: - whether <i>a posteriori</i> or <i>a priori</i> is the more persuasive style of argument - whether or not teleological arguments can be defended against the challenge of 'chance' - whether cosmological arguments simply jump to the conclusion of a transcendent creator, without sufficient explanation - whether or not there are logical fallacies in these arguments that cannot be overcome		
Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas of Aquinas, Paley and Hume listed above can be found in:</i> - Aquinas, <i>Summa Theologiae</i>, I.2.3 - Paley, <i>Natural Theology</i> Chapters 1 and 2 - Hume, <i>Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion</i> Part II Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Dawkins, R. (1991) <i>The Blind Watchmaker</i>, Penguin, Chapter 1 - Palmer, M. (2002) <i>The Question of God</i>, Routledge, Chapters 2 and 3		

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Arguments based on reason*	the ontological argument	- details of this argument including reference to: - Anselm - Gaunilo's criticisms - Kant's criticisms
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to arguments for the existence of God based on reason, including: - whether <i>a posteriori</i> or <i>a priori</i> is the more persuasive style of argument - whether or not existence can be treated as a predicate - whether or not the ontological argument justifies belief - whether or not there are logical fallacies in this argument that cannot be overcome	
	Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas of Anselm, Gaunilo and Kant listed above can be found in:</i> - Anselm, <i>Proslogion</i> 2 and 3 - Gaunilo, <i>In behalf of the fool</i> - Kant, <i>A critique of pure reason</i>, Second Division III.IV Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Psalm 14.1 - Van Inwagen, P. 'Necessary Being: the Ontological Argument' in Stump, E and Murray, M. J. (ed) (1999) <i>Philosophy of Religion: The Big Questions</i>, Blackwell - Plantinga, A. (1978) <i>God, Freedom and Evil</i>, Grand Rapids, II.c	

3. God and the World

Learners will study the nature and influence of religious experience, and the challenge posed to religious belief by the problems of evil and suffering

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Religious experience*	- the nature and influence of religious experience, including: - mystical experience - conversion experience - different ways in which individual religious experiences can be understood	- examples of mystical and conversion experiences and views about these, including: - views and main conclusions of William James - as union with a greater power - psychological effect such as illusion - the product of a physiological effect
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to religious experience, including: - whether personal testimony or witness is enough to support the validity of religious experiences - whether or not corporate religious experiences might be considered more reliable or valid than individual experiences - whether or not religious experience provides a basis for belief in God or a greater power		
Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas of William James listed above can be found in:</i> - James, W. <i>The Varieties of Religious Experience</i>, lectures 9,10,16,17 and 20 Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Acts 9.4–8, 22.6–10, 26 - Otto, R. (1923/1968) <i>The Idea of the Holy</i>, Oxford University Press, Chapters 4 and 5 - Saint Teresa of Avila, from <i>The Autobiography of Saint Teresa</i> (1960/2010) Allison Peers, E. (ed. and trans.) Dover Publications		

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
The problem of evil*	- the problem of evil and suffering: - different presentations - theodicies that propose some justification or reason for divine action or inaction in the face of evil	- including its logical (the inconsistency between divine attributes and the presence of evil) and evidential (the evidence of so much terrible evil in the world) aspects - Augustine's use of original perfection and the Fall - Hick's reworking of the Irenaean theodicy which gives some purpose to natural evil in enabling human beings to reach divine likeness
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to the problem of evil, including: - whether or not Augustine's view of the origins of moral and natural evils is enough to spare God from blame for evils in the world - whether or not the need to create a 'vale of soul-making' can justify the existence or extent of evils - which of the logical or evidential aspects of the problem of evil pose the greater challenge to belief - whether or not it is possible to successfully defend monotheism in the face of evil	
	Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas of Augustine and Hick listed above can be found in:</i> - Augustine, <i>The City of God</i> Part II - Hick, J. <i>Evil and the God of Love</i>, Part IV Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Genesis 2:4–25, 3:1–24 - Romans 5:12–13 - Augustine, 'What is evil?' in Davies, B. (2000) <i>Philosophy of Religion: a guide and anthology</i>, Oxford University Press	

4. Theological and Philosophical Developments

Learners will examine how philosophy of religion has, over time, influenced and been influenced by developments in religious beliefs about the nature of God

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
The nature or attributes of God	- developments in the understanding of: - omnipotence - omniscience (omni)benevolence - eternity - free will	- divine power and self-imposed limitation - divine knowledge and its interaction with temporal existence and free will - divine benevolence and just judgement of human actions, including Boethius's argument relating this to divine foreknowledge, eternity and free will - divine eternity and divine action in time, including Anselm's four-dimensionalist approach as an extension of Boethius's view - the extent to which human free will reasonably coexists with these attributes - the above should be studied with reference to alternative possibilities presented by Boethius, Anselm and Swinburne
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to developments in the understanding of the nature of God and the different possibilities presented by the key thinkers, including: - whether or not it is possible, or necessary, to resolve the apparent conflicts between divine attributes - whether Boethius, Anselm or Swinburne provides the most useful understanding of the relationship between divinity and time - whether or not any of these thinkers are successful in resolving the problems of divine knowledge, benevolence, justice, eternity and human free will - whether the attributes should be understood as subject to the limits of logical possibility or of divine self-limitation		
Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas of Boethius, Anselm and Swinburne listed above can be found in:</i> - Boethius, <i>Consolation of Philosophy</i>, Book V - Anselm, <i>De Concordia</i> - Swinburne, R. <i>the Coherence of Theism</i>, Part II Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Matthew 19:23–26 - Vardy, P. (1999) <i>The Puzzle of God</i>, Harper Collins, Section 4 - Macquarrie, J. (1966) <i>Principles of Christian Theology</i>, SCM Press, Chapter 11		

5. Religious Language: Negative, Analogical or Symbolic

Learners will study different views about the understanding of religious teachings, and compare the significant ideas presented in works of two key scholars

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Religious language: Negative, Analogical or Symbolic	- the apophatic way – the <i>via negativa</i> - cataphatic way – the <i>via positiva</i> - symbol	- the argument that theological language is best approached by negation - the understanding of religious language in terms of analogy, with reference to: - Aquinas's analogy of attribution and analogy of proper proportion - understanding of the language of religious expression in terms of symbol, with reference to: - Tillich's view of theological language as almost entirely symbolic
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to different views of religious language, including: - comparison of the usefulness of the above approaches to religious language - whether or not the apophatic way enables effective understanding of theological discussion - whether or not Aquinas' analogical approaches support effective expression of language about God - whether or not religious discourse is comprehensible if religious language is understood as symbolic	
	Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas of Aquinas and Tillich listed above can be found in:</i> - Aquinas, <i>Summa Theologiae</i> I.13 - Tillich, <i>Dynamics of Faith</i>, Part 3 Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Ayer, A. J. (2001) <i>Language, Truth and Logic</i>, Dover Publications - Swinburne, R. (1997) 'God-talk is not evidently nonsense' in Davies, B. (2000) <i>Philosophy of Religion: a guide and anthology</i>, Oxford University Press - Internet Encyclopaedia of Philosophy, <i>Religious Language</i>, http://www.iep.utm.edu/rel-lang/	

6. Religious Language: Twentieth Century Perspectives

Learners will study how views of religious language have changed over time, studying a variety of approaches and views

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Twentieth-century perspectives and philosophical comparisons	- logical positivism - Wittgenstein's views on language games and forms of life - discussion about the factual quality of religious language in the falsification symposium	- the impact of the verification principle on the use of religious language, with reference to: - Ayer's approach to verification - how language games may permit religious language to be deemed meaningful yet not cognitive - the varying arguments, with their associated parables, put forward in relation to theological language by: - Flew, Hare and Mitchell in their contributions to the symposium
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to different views of religious language, including: - whether or not any version of the verification principle successfully renders religious language as meaningless - whether or not any participant in the falsification symposium presented a convincing approach to the understanding of religious language - a comparison of the ideas of Aquinas and Wittgenstein, including: - whether a cognitive approach (such as Aquinas's thinking on analogy) or a non-cognitive approach (such as the language games concept of Wittgenstein) present better ways of making sense of religious language - the influence of non-cognitive approaches on the interpretation of religious texts - how far Aquinas' analogical view of theological language remains valuable in philosophy of religion	
	Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas of Ayer and Wittgenstein listed above can be found in:</i> - Ayer, A. J. <i>God Talk is Evidently Nonsense</i> - Wittgenstein, L. <i>Philosophical Investigations</i> Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Swinburne, R. (1993) <i>The Coherence of Theism</i>, Oxford University Press, Part I - Internet Encyclopaedia of Philosophy, <i>Religious Language</i>, http://www.iep.utm.edu/rel-lang/	